

Tutorial 2: Flow Over a Cylinder

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CLL769: Applications of CFD

1 Problem Statement & Objective

The objective is to perform 2D numerical simulations of unsteady flow of a Newtonian, incompressible fluid over a cylinder to study vortex shedding. The system consists of a domain of 15×5 m with a cylinder of diameter $D = 1$ m located 5 m from the inlet. Flow regimes studied are Laminar ($Re = 272$) and Turbulent ($Re = 2902$) with an inlet velocity $U = 0.5$ m/s and density $\rho = 1$ kg/m³.

2 Computational Setup

A velocity inlet of 0.5 m/s and a pressure outlet (0 gauge) were used, alongside no-slip conditions on walls and the cylinder. A pressure-based, transient, planar solver was utilized with the SIMPLE algorithm, QUICK momentum discretization, and 2nd Order Implicit transient formulation. The laminar case utilized the Laminar viscous model, while the turbulent case utilized the Standard $k - \epsilon$ model.

3 Geometry & Meshing

An unstructured mesh with inflation layers near the cylinder was generated. The grid is highly refined near the cylinder walls to capture the boundary layer separation and wake dynamics accurately, while far-field regions are slightly coarser to optimize computational cost.

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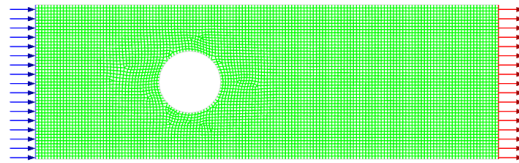


Figure 1: Computational grid around the cylinder.

4 Results & Discussion

4.1 Frequency Analysis

The y-velocity at a point behind the cylinder was monitored. For the laminar case ($Re = 272$), the oscillation period T from the probe data was approximately 9.5 s, yielding a shedding frequency $f \approx 0.105$ Hz. This aligns well with the expected theoretical Strouhal number $St = fD/U \approx 0.20$ (the simulated St is 0.21). For the turbulent case ($Re = 2902$), the oscillation period T was approximately 7.5 s, yielding a shedding frequency $f \approx 0.133$ Hz ($St_{sim} \approx 0.27$). This overpredicts the theoretical expected Strouhal number for this regime ($St \approx 0.20$). This discrepancy demonstrates a known limitation of the Standard $k - \epsilon$ model, which struggles to accurately predict frequencies in unsteadily separating flows due to the over-generation of turbulent viscosity in the wake.

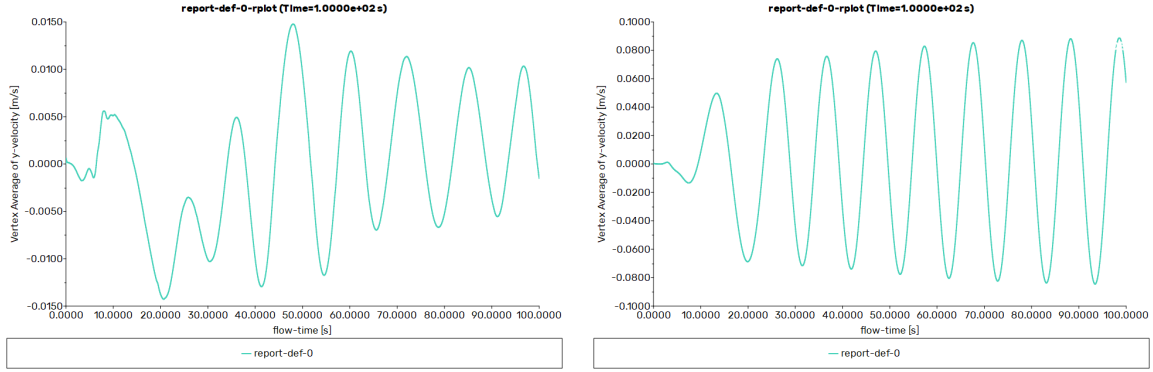


Figure 2: Frequency analysis probe data. Left: Laminar. Right: Turbulent.

4.2 Animation

A solution animation was recorded during the transient simulation to capture the dynamics of the wake formation and the vortex shedding process over time. **Watch Animation:** [Click here to view the video on GitHub!](#)